

India has the 18th-largest exclusive economic zone (EEZ) with a total size of 2,305,143 km² (890,021 sq mi). It includes the Lakshadweep island group in the Laccadive Sea off the southwestern coast of India and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands in the Bay of Bengal and the Andaman Sea. India's EEZ is bordered to the west by Pakistan, to the south by the Maldives and Sri Lanka and to the east by Bangladesh, Myanmar, Thailand, Malaysia and Indonesia. Based on new scientific data, India has petitioned United Nations to extend its EEZ from 200 Nautical miles to 350 nautical miles.

Historic context

Legal framework

India legally defined the concept of EEZ in the "Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976". In June 1997, India also ratified UNCLOS. India also enacted the "Maritime Zones of India (Regulation of fishing by foreign vessels) Act, 1981" prohibiting fishing by foreign vessel within Indian EEZ without a license. Additionally, India has also enacted laws regulation the fishing and fisheries by Indian fishing vessels operating in the EEZ.

Importance of EEZ

Economic importance

An EEZ provides a nation greater access to oil, natural gas, minerals, commercial fishing and other marine resources, freedom of navigation, international trade, national security, and strategic leverage over other nations. With 7,500 km coastline and an EEZ of over 2.3 million km², India has exclusive control over the resources in its EEZ including navigation of seafaring trade and transport vessels in this area. As per 2014 study, India exploits only 3.2 million tonnes per year marine fishery resources out of potential 3.92 million tonne in its coastal areas.

Regional maritime security

Piracy, poaching or illegal fishing by foreign vessels, freedom of navigation, transgression of foreign vessels into Indian EEZ, and conflicting claims are major issues in EEZ. Piracy in the Strait of Malacca is a major concern for all the nations. Studies have shown decline in fishing stocks and destruction of several marine ecological areas in Indian EEZ due to organized illegal poaching and fishing resulting in depletion of many endangered and threatened species. Freedom of the navigation has become a cause of concern due to piracy. National security is also threatened by actions of China around Indian EEZ. Conflicting claims over EEZ by nations leads to disputes, such as India-Pakistan Sir Creek dispute. In the past, UNCLOS has granted several contradicting claims while increasing the EEZ based on the evidence related to the length of continental shelf. These UNCLOS contradictions have resulted into overlapping EEZ claims by several nations competing for the resources in the expanded EEZ.

National security and geostrategy

The Indian Coast Guard near the shore and the Indian Military's integrated Andaman and Nicobar Command off-shore play the important role in protecting India's EEZ while exercising control over the geostratgically important channels in Bay of Bengal and the important international chokepoint of Strait of Malacca.

India's EEZ

India's existing EEZ area

India's increased EEZ claim area

Summary of new claims

Arabia Sea - India's 2025 revised new claims under review by CLCS

As of early 2026, India is actively pursuing an expanded maritime claim, specifically focusing

on its Extended Continental Shelf (ECS) in the Central Arabian Sea. The new claims are based on updated technical data from India's National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR), providing evidence that the seabed is a natural prolongation of India's landmass. In April 2025, after India's original 2009 claim was rejected by the Commission on the Limits of the Continental Shelf (CLCS) in March 2023 due to objections from Pakistan regarding the Sir Creek area, India submitted revised partial claims for the Central Arabian Sea by splitting its submission to isolate disputed Sir Creek areas from uncontested ones, allowing the CLCS to review in the 64th CLCS session (August 2025), with ongoing consultations likely extending into 2026. If accepted, this extension, combined with the 2 million km² EEZ, would give India control over a total seabed area of roughly 3.2 million km², nearly equal to its total landmass. In the Sir Creek dispute Pakistan objects to India's EEZ claims in the Western Arabian Sea, resulting in an EEZ claim overlap of 100 nautical miles. If granted, the total seabed area under Indian jurisdiction would nearly equal its terrestrial landmass, providing exclusive rights to explore polymetallic nodules and hydrocarbons.

Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean - India's 2025 revised new claims under review by CLCS
India has also claimed additional 300,000 square km in the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean, which are under evaluation.

2009-2010 claims by India - rejected by CLCS in March 2023 due to objections by Pakistan
Earlier in 2009-2010, based on the new 6,000 pages sedimentary and scientific evidence, India petitioned United Nations for increasing Indian EEZ from 200 nautical miles to 350 nautical miles. Extension of EEZ from 200 to 350 nautical mile will almost double India's present EEZ. UNCLOS permits extension of EEZ beyond the usual 200 nautical miles limit, to a maximum of 350 nautical miles, if the evidence shows that continental shelf extends beyond 200 nautical miles. For the integrated management and mapping of the EEZ, India's Ministry of Earth

Sciences (MoES) initiated an ongoing project in 1999 which was only 30% complete in 2018. A team of 60 scientists from several national institutes began undertaking multi-disciplinary studies on geo-scientific mapping, physiography, sedimentology, paleoclimatology and Himalayan tectonics, hydrology of India and monsoon of South Asia, mineral resource availability. Scientists and researchers involved in the studies come from several institutes and universities, such as the National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR), National Institute of Oceanography, India (NIO), National Institute of Ocean Technology (NIOT), Geological Survey of India (GSI) and many universities. These studies also enhance the preparedness against environmental hazards and socio-economic well-being of people living in Coastal India.

Neighbouring EEZs

Neighbouring EEZ of other nations from west to east are:

Gallery

See also

Climate of India

Borders of India

Disputed territories of India

Extreme points of India

Geography of India

Outline of India

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